exact number of people she fed every day, but I am quite certain that far more outsiders ate with us than al the members of our own family put together.

My parents were widely regarded as an ideal couple.

My mother’s lineage was the more distinguished, one of her forebears having been bestowed the title of ‘Bahadur’ by the British.

I was one of many children—a short boy with rather undistinguished looks, born to tal and handsome parents.

We lived in our ancestral house, which was built in the middle of the 19th century. It was a fairly large pucca house, made of limestone and brick, on the Mosque Street in Rameswaram. My austere father used to avoid al inessential comforts and luxuries. However, al necessities were provided for, in terms of food, medicine or clothes. In fact, I would say mine was a very secure childhood, both material y and emotional y.

I normal y ate with my mother, sitting on the floor of the kitchen. She would place a banana leaf before me, on which she then ladled rice and aromatic sambhar, a variety of sharp, home-made pickles and a dol op of fresh coconut chutney.